Sara Rabino

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Education

2021–Now **PhD in Economics**, *University of Zürich*
Advisors: Ana Costa-Ramón, Roberto A. Weber

2025–2026 **Visiting Fellow**, *Harvard University*
Host: Katherine B. Coffman

2018–2021 **MSc in Economic and Social Sciences**, *Bocconi University*
Thesis Supervisor: Jérôme Adda, Final Grade: 110/110 cum laude

2015–2018 **BSc in Economic and Social Sciences**, *Bocconi University*
Thesis Supervisor: Tommaso Monacelli, Final Grade: 110/110 cum laude

2018 **Exchange Program**, *University College London*

Research Interests

Behavioral Economics, Gender Economics, Labor Economics

Job Market Paper

Making a Difference? The Role of Social Impact in College Major Choice
(with Ana Brás-Monteiro and Samantha Stelnicki)

Work is not only a means of earning a living, it can also be a source of meaning through the contribution people feel they make to society. Because the choice of academic major largely shapes future career paths, we ask: do students hold accurate perceptions of how fulfilling different fields are in terms of social impact, and how do these perceptions shape major choices? We address these questions through a survey experiment at a large U.S. public university. We find that students substantially underestimate how satisfied previous graduates report being with their contribution, with significant heterogeneity in the extent of underestimation by field. These beliefs are consistent with stereotyping: students believe that graduates in fields such as Health and Social Sciences are much more likely to be satisfied with their contribution than graduates in Physics & Mathematics or Computer Science, while nationally representative data on college graduates shows the gap is much smaller. We show that randomly providing information on previous graduates' experiences of impact across all fields significantly shifts students' perceptions, with revisions proportional to their initial misperceptions. These revised beliefs lead students who value social contribution to recommend a broader set of majors to like-minded peers. We see more limited effects on students' intentions and class enrollment, with significant changes in intentions only among women, who value social impact most and shift toward fields whose social impact they had underestimated.

Work in Progress

Is Social Learning Gendered?
(with Kobbina Awuah, Stine Helmke, Rafael Hernández-Pachón, Urša Krenk, Daniela Santos Cárdenas and David Yanagizawa-Drott)

We ask whether individuals' economic decisions are influenced by the average behavior of peers with similar economic characteristics, and whether this response depends on gender: do women respond more strongly to information about other similar women's choices, and men to information about other similar men's? To answer these questions, we partner with a microfinance institution in Kenya, a setting with substantial gender gaps in credit demand. We embed an experiment in the institution's routine loan-application phone call. Applicants are randomly assigned to hear the average amount requested

by a random sample of similar past borrowers (same area, age bracket, and sector). Depending on the treatment arm, this sample consists of male borrowers, female borrowers, or borrowers in general, with no gender specified. We estimate the causal effect of each type of information on applicants' final requested amounts, as well as on the amounts later granted and repaid. Preliminary results show that information about the amount others requested shifts credit demand and that, conditional on the amount communicated, both women and men respond more strongly to information about peers of their own gender.

How Men and Women Want to Do (and Look) Good: Effective Altruism vs Warm Glow

When monetary donations yield the same or even higher social outcome than working directly for the cause, which way of making an impact do people choose, and why? A reason they may not be indifferent is warm glow: the satisfaction of contributing in person, beyond the impact produced. Another is social image, if helping directly signals prosociality in a way that donating does not. Both may operate differently for women, who report stronger preferences for meaningful work and are more often expected to be prosocial. In this experiment, participants choose between two hypothetical jobs: assembling and delivering meals to people in need themselves, or working for pay and donating part or all of the wage to the same non-profit. Using a multiple price list, I vary in the second option the number of meals the donation funds and the private earnings retained, and estimate how these trade-offs differ by gender. To separate warm glow from social image, I randomize whether choices are shown to a sample of spectators, who predict what a man or a woman participant chose and then judge how much that person cares about helping others.

Infidelity and Marital Resource Allocation
(with Stine Helmke)

Infidelity is widespread in Sub-Saharan Africa, especially among men. We study the relationship between infidelity and resource allocation between spouses: when wives expect their husbands to be unfaithful, do they share less of their resources with their husbands, or more? And does the prospect of wives gaining control over resources affect husbands' infidelity? We investigate these questions in three experiments in Dar es Salaam, Tanzania. First, we use a list experiment to measure the prevalence of infidelity in local communities. Second, we run an experiment with wives, where we provide randomized information about local infidelity rates and let them choose how to split a one-year income subsidy between themselves and their husbands. Third, we run an experiment with husbands, where we inform a random sample that their wife may receive an income subsidy of varying size in the future. Six months later, we measure their infidelity through private reports from their wives.

Teaching

2024 **Lecturer**, *University of Zürich*
The Economics of Gender Norms (BA)

2023–2024 **Teaching Assistant**, *University of Zürich*
Econometrics for Research Students, Part II (PhD)

2023–Now **Thesis Supervision**, *University of Zürich*
Students: Oliver Schwertfeger (2024), Elto Nathanaël Wolde (2024), Zhao Meng (2023), Hannah Talary (2023)

2016–2020 **Teaching Assistant**, *Bocconi University*
IT Education Center (BA)

Work Experience

2023 **Research Assistant**, *University of Zürich*
For David Yanagizawa-Drott and Anne Ardila Brenøe

2020–2021 **Research Assistant**, *IGIER, Bocconi University*
For Thomas Le Barbanchon and Jérôme Adda

2020 **Research Assistant**, *Bocconi University*
For Tommaso Nannicini

Grants

2025 UZH Candoc Grant (CHF 61,661)

2025 URPP Research Grant (CHF 7,011)

Scholarships & Awards

2024 URPP Senior PhD Scholarship

2023 URPP Early-stage PhD Scholarship

2018 Bocconi Graduate Merit Award, full-waiver scholarship

Presentations

2026 ACME Seminar (Harvard Graduate School of Education); EALE (Universitat de Barcelona); LEER (KU Leuven); PhD Workshop in Labor and Behavioral Economics (CEBI, University of Copenhagen); IWAEE (Catanzaro); NCBEE (Hanken School of Economics and Helsinki GSE)

2025 EER Summer School in Behavioral and Experimental Economics (LUISS, Rome); MIT Behavioral Student Lunch

2024 Economics of Breastfeeding (Engelberg)

Public Service

2027 **Organizer**, *PhD Workshop in Labor and Behavioral Economics*, University of Zürich

2024 **Organizer**, *UZH Doctoral Labor Seminar*, University of Zürich

2023 **Organizer**, *UZH Third-year Seminar*, University of Zürich

2023 **Volunteer**, *Graduate Applications International Network (GAIN)*

2019–2022 **Senior Fellow**, *Tortuga Think Tank*

Computer Skills

Office, Stata, Python, MatLab: good

RStudio, Eviews: beginner

Languages

Italian	Mothertongue
English	Fluent
French	Intermediate
German	Basic

References

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